



K. MURALI KUMAR

bowler burst onto the scene in 2022 with searing pace and was fast-tracked into the Indian team, but has since retreated to the peripheries, having featured in just 10 ODIs and eight T20Is. His inexperience showed, as he missed his lengths often and was guilty of spraying the ball on both sides of the wicket.

Umran's case is not a one-off. Kolkata Knight Riders batter Venkatesh Iyer earned a call-up to the national squad in 2021 after he played a stellar role in the second leg of that year's IPL to turn Knight Riders' season around. But after just two ODIs and nine T20Is, Iyer too has been searching for a comeback opportunity.

Another example is KKR mystery spinner Varun Chakravarthy, who made the cut for the 2021 T20 World Cup squad after having impressed since the 2020 IPL where he took big wickets.

However, in IPL 2022, his form plummeted so much that he was benched for three games. He eventually fell out of favour with the

national selectors after playing only six T20Is.

For now, Mayank has shown glimpses of talent that promise to make him a force for a long time and a generational cricketer. "His delivery to dismiss RCB's Cameron Green (above), who hails from Western Australia where fast bowlers abound, speaks volumes. Mayank consistently clocks speeds of 150-plus, a feat few can match. As a fast-bowling coach, I take pride in India's potential to produce superior fast bowlers in the years to come," Sekar said.

Given the way Mayank is bowling, there are already talks of carrying him as a spare pacer for the Border-Gavaskar Trophy in Australia later this year. But five-day cricket will put too much load on his body, reckons Sekar. "To succeed there, he needs to work on his technique, especially his feet alignment. His front leg is going slightly outside the back leg; as of now, he is not using the non-bowling arm much. These are the things he could fine-tune," he said.

Sekar has been following Mayank

for the last three years. He saw him perform in the U-23 category in Pondicherry and then again in 2022 during the Mumbai Indians trials. He knew then that Mayank was cut from a different cloth.

But Mayank's focus for now needs to be on being fit. He walked off after bowling just one over against Gujarat Titans in Lucknow. Before he left the field, Mayank's pace had dropped below 140 kmph, and he was hit for three boundaries in the fourth over of Gujarat Titans's unsuccessful chase of LSG's 163 for 5. Mayank has had a history of injuries, which ruled him out of the last IPL and restricted him to just one first-class match.

LSG CEO Vinod Bisht said: "Mayank felt soreness in lower abdominal area and as a precaution we are managing his work load over next week. We hope to see him soon in the field."

Needless to say, Mayank needs to be wrapped up in cotton wool while he continues to bowl thunderbolts and tick the boxes he is required to tick on a given day. India selection will take care of itself.